Research Track

CAIN 2027

Review Instructions

DISCLAIMER: These review instructions are heavily inspired by similar instructions for conferences like ICSE (https://conf.researchr.org/track/icse-2026/icse-2026-research-track#Call-for-Papers), ICSA (https://conf.researchr.org/track/icsa-2025/icsa-2025-papers?#Review-Instructions), and ECSA (https://conf.researchr.org/track/ecsa-2025/ecsa-2025-call-for-research-papers#Review-Instructions).

CAIN's goal is to facilitate an inclusive and transparent review process. To this end, we outline the quality criteria for reviews in this document, which makes it important for both authors and reviewers.

1. What We Expect of CAIN Reviewers

In general, we encourage our reviewers to be open, positive, and professional. Look for reasons to accept a paper rather than primarily for reasons to reject. Beyond that, we have additional expectations for their work.

- **Take responsibility**: We invited you as a PC member because of your expertise. Therefore, we expect you to take full responsibility for your reviews. Reviewers may solicit help from others acting as sub-reviewers or use the reviews as an opportunity to train their PhD students. However, reviewers should rewrite the review in their own words and adjust the scores accordingly. The final opinions in a submitted review should be those of the PC member, not those of a sub-reviewer.
- **Responsible/no AI use**: Again, we invited you as a PC member because of your expertise and expect you to take full responsibility for your reviews. Delegating reviews to AI is unprofessional and not allowed. Uploading papers under review to a public generative AI platform that may train on the paper content is strictly forbidden, as this would be considered as a violation of confidentiality of the process. However, responsible use of private AI (or AI services with privacy guarantees), for example to help format the review or help explore specific questions about the paper or related work is acceptable – for example, see Murphy-Hill and Bird's post on this (https://cabird.com/ide/posts/ai-in-peer-review). AI use must be disclosed in the review form. We will hold reviewers accountable for AI slop and hallucinations. Ultimately, we insist that the reviews must be your professional judgment.
- **Participate in the bidding**: Reviewers should pay attention to the bidding process to select papers that are close to their area of expertise. This will make it easier to assign reviewers with sufficient expertise in the topic and used research methods.
- **Ensure review quality**: We ask PC members to submit thorough and balanced reviews that justify their verdict well. High-quality reviews do not have to be several pages long, but it's unlikely that a few sentences will constitute a high-quality review.

- **See the positive**: Almost every paper has some flaws, even award winning accepted ones. Try to review papers with a positive attitude and give papers a fair chance. Balance positives with negatives and deliberate about what problems are acceptable or can be easily fixed (e.g., presentation weaknesses, limited generalization, missing related work) and what problems are so serious that the paper should not be published in its current form (e.g., unsound claims, methodological flaws, missing novelty over prior paper). There is no limit on the number of papers that can be accepted to CAIN and no need to rank papers relative to other papers. CAIN is a community event and strives to include all papers that make sound contributions valuable to the community.
- **Describe what is missing**: Even if you think that a paper does not meet the standards required for acceptance, we encourage you to highlight what you think would be necessary to make it acceptable, while acknowledging that conference submissions are subject to page limits (authors cannot include everything).
- **Take a stand**: If you have expertise on the topic, try to take a clear stance for or against the paper. Expertise could be on the topic (e.g., ML monitoring) or the research method (e.g., qualitative analysis of interview data) or both. You are on the PC because others want to know your expert judgment. “Weak accept” and “weak reject” are more commonly used for reviews with less confidence, often outside your area of expertise. Junior PC members may be experts on fewer papers, but they should still leverage their expertise where they are experts.
- **Report ethical issues**: PC members should inform the PC co-chairs immediately if they detect evidence related to plagiarism, concurrent submissions, unethical GenAI usage, exposure of private participant data, co-reviewers demanding unreasonable citations of their work, etc.
- **Update reviews where reasonable**: Reviews can be updated at any time, and we encourage reviewers to read the submitted reviews of others and to potentially make adjustments even before the discussion period. If the discussion led to a decision that is inconsistent with the initial reviews and their scores, we ask you to update both to reflect the consensus reached during the discussion. For example, a rejected paper should not have mostly accept scores.
- **Engage in discussions:** Discuss with other reviewers about the strength and the weaknesses of the paper. Read the other reviews and respond where you agree or disagree with their key points, as questions where answers might help move the discussion forward (by better understanding disagreements or reaching consensus). Engage with the other reviewers’ arguments rather than just restating your own. Try to respond quickly (same day or next day) and constructively.
- **Argue your position but be open to changing your mind:** You are on the PC because you have expertise. You have expertise and may see strengths and weaknesses that others with different backgrounds may not recognize. Even if the paper is not in your area of expertise, your opinion of how well the paper explains its contributions to an outsider is still valuable. If you think a paper makes a strong contribution and should be accepted (maybe despite some weaknesses), fight for it. If you think a paper is fundamentally flawed and should not be published in its current form, argue your position. Do not simply follow the majority or defer to more senior PC members. At the same time, listen to other reviewers and read the authors’ response (if available). Be open to change your mind if you see other convincing arguments or find mistakes in yours. Maybe others see strengths that you did not appreciate.

2. Review Criteria

Reviewers will evaluate each submission according to several criteria (see below). We ask reviewers to explicitly use these criteria in the review, e.g., to structure the detailed comments or by providing a brief summary for each criterion at the end of the detailed comments.

- **Novelty**: The extent to which the paper is original and positioned regarding the state-of-the-art. Note that novelty is not about providing “surprising,” “unexpected,” or “important” results or the complexity of a proposed solution. Instead, it is about how the work advances the existing body of knowledge. If

insufficient empirical evidence exists for a phenomenon, then providing this evidence is novel, even if the results are not surprising. Papers should explain novelty with respect to the state of the art clearly. Lastly, we also encourage replications, i.e., papers that confirm previous findings, e.g., in slightly different contexts. These papers need to discuss their findings in comparison to previous works.

- **Relevance to CAIN scope**: The extent to which the paper fits the scope outlined in the Call for Papers and to which the paper's contributions are important for AI engineering research, practice, and education / training. Authors are expected to explain relevance during submission and as part of the paper. Submissions out of scope may be desk rejected.
- **Rigor**: The extent to which the paper's claims and contributions are supported by the rigorous application of appropriate research methods, e.g., within an empirical study. For a theoretical or design contribution, this refers to its soundness, clarity, and depth. For a design contribution, this additionally refers to the level of thoroughness and completeness of the evaluation. Design contributions presented in full research papers must be appropriately evaluated. However, a short paper presenting innovative solution ideas does not require an extensive evaluation but should instead provide sound arguments and convincing future plans for the evaluation.
- **Verifiability & Transparency**: The extent to which the paper provides methodological details to understand how the authors arrived at their conclusions and shares study data and artifacts that support the independent verification or replication of the paper's claimed contributions.
- **Presentation**: The extent to which the paper's writing is clear and efficiently understandable, with well-organized descriptions and explanations.

3. Review Form

Reviewers will use the following form to structure their reviews:

- **Overall merit**: please provide an overall verdict for the paper using one of the following scores:
  - Reject (1): the paper has too many major weaknesses to be publishable in its current form and I will argue to reject it
  - Weak reject (2): the paper has some major weaknesses but also some merit; but I am not confident enough to argue for rejection and may be convinced by others
  - Weak accept (3): the paper has merits, but I am not confident enough to argue for acceptance and may be convinced by others
  - Accept (4): the paper has considerable merit and only very few, mostly minor weaknesses; I am ready to champion this paper
  - Award-quality paper (5): this is an award-quality paper with considerable potential to advance the field; it should definitely be accepted
- **Expertise** (not confidence):
  - X. I am an expert on this topic or research method (know the related work well)
  - Y. I am knowledgeable on this topic or research method.
  - Z. I am an informed outsider.
- **Paper summary**: please briefly summarize your understanding of the paper's content, ideally at least partially in your own words (~2–8 sentences)
- **Summary of strengths**: 2-4 short bullet points of the paper's main strengths (which are explained in more details in the comments section below)
- **Summary of weaknesses**: 2-4 short bullet points of the paper's main weaknesses (which are explained in more details in the comments section below)
- **Detailed comments**: explain and justify your verdict and the provided strengths and weaknesses; if you argue for rejection, make sure to provide at least some constructive criticism for the authors to improve their submission; additionally, please ensure that you make explicit use of the review criteria (see

above), e.g., by structuring your review via these criteria or by having a summary of them at the end. Ensure that your summary bullet points are a reflection of these comments.

Important Dates

AoE (UTC-12h)

Fri 30 Oct 2026
Submission deadline

Mon 11 Jan 2027
Notifications

Fri 29 Jan 2027
Camera ready deadline

Program Committee (https://conf.researchr.org/committee/cain-2027/cain-2027-call-for-papers-program-committee)



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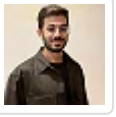
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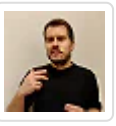


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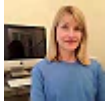
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